

EG Geo-technology, China, United States: Trump 2.0 to widen and soften anti-Huawei telecom strategy

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Geo-technology, China, United States

13 Jul 2026 15:52 EDT

Trump 2.0 to widen and soften anti-Huawei telecom strategy

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- * To preserve stability in the bilateral relationship with China, the US is unlikely to resume its pressure campaign to convince countries to ban Huawei 5G and 6G equipment.
 - * Instead, the US is likely to adopt a softer approach in which it highlights the risks of untrusted providers but doesn't push for bans; however, it will expand these efforts to cover additional countries and telecoms technologies.
 - * Restrictions on untrusted providers of telecoms infrastructure supporting AI data center buildouts may become a new area of focus.
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The US is unlikely to reboot a full-scale pressure campaign to ban Huawei and ZTE. During President Donald Trump's first term in office, the US established the Clean Network program to pressure primarily European and Indo-Pacific allies to ban untrusted vendors—namely China's Huawei and ZTE—from their 5G network rollouts. Additionally, the US sought to limit Huawei's access to US chips by adding the company to the US Commerce Department Entity List. The second Trump administration has not revived the Clean Network program.

The new focus on stability in China ties increases the likelihood of a softer approach in Trump's second term. Following the recent summit with Chinese President Xi Jinping, Trump will avoid inflaming tensions with China, slowing technology decoupling efforts (see: Low-yield summit boosts Xi's standing and near-term stability , 20 May 2026). Beijing had perceived past US pushes to ban Huawei as escalatory. Moreover, the US has also already achieved most of its objectives on 5G with its allies and partners. As a result, the US is unlikely to launch an aggressive public pressure campaign to compel countries to ban Huawei 6G.

For 5G and 6G rollouts, the US is likely to highlight untrusted provider risks. US government officials will encourage countries to phase out untrusted vendors as they naturally upgrade their telecommunications infrastructure. Many US allies in Europe and the Indo-Pacific are in the process of placing restrictions on untrusted providers in their telecommunications infrastructure, and the US is unlikely to push countries

for further restrictions or bans (see: Huawei and ZTE in the crosshairs as governments continue to restrict role of Chinese telecom vendors , 2 November 2022; Brussels's bid to ban Huawei will face significant pushback , 27 January 2026). Because 6G builds on 5G technologically, a vendor lock-in effect increases the likelihood that US allies that have already phased out Chinese gear will not switch to Huawei and ZTE in 6G rollouts.

Trump 2.0's anti-Huawei strategy will extend to other countries and telecoms technologies. The US approach is expected to be similarly light touch with countries outside of Europe and the Indo-Pacific, where the US has a smaller footprint, less exposure to risk, and therefore even less incentive to push for a ban. The US likely will use different tools to advance its agenda, including trade agreements. For example, the US has included language in several Agreements on Reciprocal Trade to ensure countries use ICT infrastructure—including 5G, 6G, satellites, and undersea cables—that does not compromise security, safeguards, and intellectual property. The agreements request that countries consult with the US on which suppliers are unable to meet those standards. To date, the US has negotiated nine agreements and included ICT trusted provider provisions in those with Argentina, El Salvador, Guatemala, Indonesia, and Taiwan.

Telecoms infrastructure for AI data centers could be a new area of focus. In 2024, the US imposed conditions on Microsoft's \$1.5 billion investment in the UAE, which allowed the Emirati company G42 to use Microsoft cloud services to run AI applications. In exchange, G42 agreed to strip Huawei out of its telecommunications networks, sideline Huawei in G42's operations, end its partnership with Huawei's cloud service, and terminate AI research projects with Chinese tech companies. Recent Trump administration actions suggest that, given the interest in US AI tech, this approach might gain traction. For example, the US Commerce Department's Bureau of Industry and Security's draft AI diffusion replacement rule, which was placed on hold, focused on protecting data centers. Additionally, a US Federal Communications Commission proposed rule from 30 April would prevent Chinese telecommunications companies on the Covered List from operating their data centers in the US. Data center projects most at risk of this conditionality are those that primarily run training models (versus inference models) and are located in a country with a viable alternative to Huawei or ZTE networks or fiber optic cables. If an alternative to Huawei or ZTE kit exists, the US is likely to push for the relocation of data center projects in the country.

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